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Life-crisis rituals among the Kenuz

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The women then congratulated the girl, saying, "You're a female now," and "You have become a bride." Some of them called out joking comments: "Bring her a groom," and "Bring her a cock; now she's ready for fucking." One woman wrapped the girl in a white shogga. Her mother came out of the house to place two necklaces around her daughter's throat. One was silver, obtained from a sheikh, to protect her against any form of the evil eye. Another, of gold, would guard her against mushahra conveyed by this substance when worn by any visitors. She lifted the girl in her arms and carried her out through the courtyard gate, standing in the street for a few moments before returning. By leaving and re-entering before any visitors had come, she hoped to avert any mushahra that they might bring. She laid the girl, who was still screaming, on a mat in the *sebil*, where the other children gathered around her, and tried to coax her into eating hard-boiled eggs to compensate for the blood she had lost.

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The mother then began the celebration by offering her guests perfume and candy. After this she served a karama consisting of lentil soup with bread. Some of the women said that she had vowed to do this for her daughter's excision. Others, who were probably more accurate, described it as customary. During the meal, other women came to offer their congratulations. Those who were more thoughtful did so by calling these over the courtyard

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wall in the approved way, without endangering the child by bringing mushahra inside. Others entered the court for this purpose, which in spite of the precautions that had been taken was held to be dangerous until the new moon had appeared. One of the guests began making a hejab for the girl by placing baraka seeds and ground coffee in a square of white cloth, which the mother sewed into a bag. Before they left, each guest handed her five to ten piastres as nokut for the girl. The midwife received a fee of thirty piastres, besides cigarettes, dates, soap, and *gargush* (a zweiback-like kind of bread that serves as an equivalent for cake). This payment was unusually high, because the girl and her mother were migrants. Residents of Dahmit were charged considerably less.

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The midwife returned after three days to clean the wound and apply more henna. By this time the girl had been able to urinate, and her recovery was now taken for granted. When FG visited the house a few days later, the child began screaming in fright on seeing her. The mother quickly assured her that this was only a visitor, and not the midwife coming back. She explained that the girl was terrified of the latter, adding that whenever she misbehaved they would warn her that the midwife was coming for her. After the girl was again able to walk, her mother took her to visit the Mehennab tribal shrine and that of Hamad.

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After her excision, a girl was vulnerable to mushahra in the same way as an infant, a woman after delivery, and a bride. While the threat of mushahra does not in itself specifically associate this operation with marriage, the forms used to congratulate an excised girl clearly link these two events. Similarly, the substances that midwives applied to the genital area after excision, while credited with healing properties, also included tobacco, sugar, or other ingredients that were regarded as having the power to attract men to her. The older preference for scheduling excisions to occur during the Nile flood explicitly associated these events with a period of fertility. Even wrapping an excised girl in her mother's shogga was significant. A shogga was probably chosen because it was white. But this garment was closely associated with marriage, and was first assumed at that event, when a bride was wrapped in a shogga for her first meeting with her husband.

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